8-Week Beginner Fat-Loss Full-Body Program (Dumbbell and Bodyweight, Knee-Friendly)

Summary

An 8-week, 3-day-per-week full-body program (Tuesday/Thursday/Saturday, about 35-40 minutes per session) for a beginner whose goal is fat loss, using only adjustable dumbbells (about 2-20 kg per hand) and bodyweight at home. All knee-dominant work is kept shallow-to-moderate because of pain with deep knee bending. Week 1 is a ramp-in at 2 sets per exercise, weeks 2-7 build volume and effort using double progression, and week 8 is a lighter deload. An optional easier week is available if you feel unusually fatigued around weeks 4-5.

Confirmed Requirements

- Goal: fat loss
- Experience: beginner
- Equipment: dumbbell (about 2-20 kg per hand), bodyweight
- Days per week: 3 (Tuesday/Thursday/Saturday)
- Session length: 40 minutes
- Constraint (injury): Pain with deep knee bending; avoid deep squats/lunges and deep knee flexion under load. Keep knee range of motion shallow-to-moderate. No other injuries.
- Notes: Home training. Adjustable dumbbells approx. 2-20 kg per hand. Schedule: Tuesday/Thursday/Saturday.

Weekly Schedule Overview

Day	Session	Focus	Target time
Tuesday	Day 1 (Tuesday) - Full Body A	Full body, push and hinge emphasis; shallow-range knee-dominant work only (knee-safe)	35 min
Thursday	Day 2 (Thursday) - Full Body B	Full body, pull and single-leg/hip emphasis; loaded carry for conditioning (knee-safe)	35 min
Saturday	Day 3 (Saturday) - Full Body C	Full body, balanced push/pull with higher-density circuit-style finish for energy expenditure	35 min

Split: Full-body (3 non-consecutive days: Tue/Thu/Sat). Duration: 8 weeks. Rest days: Monday, Wednesday, Friday, Sunday (optional walking, cycling, or swimming).

Session-by-Session Program

Sets below are the full-volume prescription (weeks 2-7); see Progression Plan for week 1 and week 8 adjustments.

Day 1 (Tuesday) - Full Body A

Exercise	Sets	Reps / time	Rest (s)
Dumbbell Floor Press	3	8-12	75
Dumbbell Romanian Deadlift	3	10-15	75
Bodyweight Squat	3	10-15	45
Dumbbell Bent-Over Row	3	8-12	60
Incline Push-Up	2	8-15	60
Plank	2	20-40 sec	45

Day 2 (Thursday) - Full Body B

Exercise	Sets	Reps / time	Rest (s)
Dumbbell Bent-Over Row	3	10-15 (slow 3-sec lowering)	75
Push-Up	3	6-12	60
Single-Leg Glute Bridge	3	8-12 per leg	60
Bodyweight Squat	2	10-15 (shallow, box-limited)	45
Dumbbell Farmer's Carry	3	30-40 sec	60
Side Plank	2	15-30 sec per side	30

Day 3 (Saturday) - Full Body C

Exercise	Sets	Reps / time	Rest (s)
Dumbbell Floor Press	2	10-15	60
Dumbbell Bent-Over Row	3	12-15	60
Bodyweight Squat	3	12-15	45
Dumbbell Romanian Deadlift	2	12-15	60
Glute Bridge (circuit station 1)	3	15 reps / 35 sec, circuit round	60
Plank (circuit station 2)	3	30 sec, circuit round	60
Dumbbell Biceps Curl (circuit station 3)	3	12-15 / 35 sec, circuit round	60
Standing Calf Raise (circuit station 4)	3	15-20 / 35 sec, circuit round	60

Note: Day 3 finishes with a 3-round, 4-station circuit (Glute Bridge, Plank, Dumbbell Biceps Curl, Standing Calf Raise): 35 sec work, 15 sec transition, 60 sec rest between rounds.

Progression Plan

Double progression within each exercise's rep range (per research.json finding for beginner fat-loss training: moderate rep ranges, 1-3 RIR, dumbbell loads capped around 20 kg). Week 1 starts one set lighter on 3-set exercises, weeks 2-7 run the prescribed sets while RIR tightens from 3 to 1-2, and week 8 is a lighter consolidation/deload. Once rep-range tops are reached, add load in small steps, or, when dumbbells cap out, add tempo, pauses, or shorter rest. Knee flexion stays shallow-to-moderate throughout. If you feel unusually fatigued or sore around weeks 4-5, take an easier week (drop to 2 sets per exercise at about 3 RIR) before continuing.

- Week 1 (ramp-in): 2 sets per exercise, about 3 reps in reserve (RIR); stay at the lower end of each rep range.
- Weeks 2-7: prescribed sets as listed above.
- Week 8 (deload): 2 sets per exercise, about 4 RIR, about 10-20% less load or an easier pace.
- Optional easier week (around weeks 4-5, only if unusually fatigued): 2 sets per exercise at about 3 RIR, then continue.

Week	Effort (RIR)	Notes
1	3 RIR (about 3 reps left)	Ramp-in, 2 sets per exercise
2	3 RIR (about 3 reps left)	Prescribed sets
3	2-3 RIR	Prescribed sets
4	2 RIR	Prescribed sets
5	2 RIR	Prescribed sets
6	1-2 RIR	Prescribed sets
7	1-2 RIR (hardest week, never to failure)	Prescribed sets
8	4 RIR (easy, about 60-70% of normal effort)	Deload

Load rule (double progression): once you hit the top of the rep range on all sets for 2 consecutive sessions with good form, increase load about 2.5-5% (smallest jump available). Dumbbells cap at about 20 kg, so when the cap is reached add reps, slow the 3-sec lowering, pause, or shorten rest. Bodyweight moves progress by reps, then tempo or pauses. Timed holds: add about 5 seconds per set.

Equipment & Substitutions

- Required: adjustable dumbbells (about 2-20 kg per hand) and bodyweight only.
- Pull exercise: Dumbbell Bent-Over Row is the only dumbbell/bodyweight pull option available. Bench rows (single-arm row, chest-supported row) are excluded because no bench is available, and the exercise database returns no bench-free substitutes. If a bench becomes available, swap db_single_arm_row into Day 2.
- Reverse Lunge was returned by the catalogue but deliberately not used (knee precaution).
- If dumbbell load caps out, progress with reps, tempo, pauses, or shorter rest.

Safety Notes

- Knee precaution: you have pain with deep knee bending. Keep knee bend shallow-to-moderate (pain-free, box-limited), and do not do deep squats, deep lunges, or loaded deep knee flexion. No loaded squats or lunges are programmed. Stop any movement that reproduces knee pain.
- Bodyweight Squat: limit depth to a pain-free shallow-to-moderate range (box or well above parallel); stop if knee pain recurs.
- Dumbbell Bent-Over Row and Romanian Deadlift: neutral spine, hinge at the hips; reduce load if your lower back fatigues.
- Pull exercises: Dumbbell Bent-Over Row (db_row) is the only available dumbbell/bodyweight pull exercise suitable for a beginner. Bench-based rows (single-arm row, chest-supported row) are excluded because you have no bench; Renegade Row is advanced and loads the wrists. db_row is therefore used in all three sessions, varied by rep range and tempo.
- Week 1 is a ramp-in (2 sets per exercise, about 3 reps in reserve). Week 8 is a deload (about 4 reps in reserve, lighter load or easier pace). Never train to true failure as a beginner.
- Optional easier week: if you feel unusually fatigued or sore around weeks 4-5, drop to 2 sets per exercise at about 3 reps in reserve for one week, then continue.
- If knee pain persists, see a clinician. The research sources are general-audience and secondary, and this program is not clinical or medical advice.
- Nutrition is the main driver of fat loss and is outside the scope of this program. Optional knee-friendly activity on off days: walking, cycling, or swimming.

Sources

- https://www.garagegymreviews.com/how-many-sets-per-muscle-group-per-week
- https://acsm.org/science-spotlight-acsm-releases-new-position-stand-on-resistance-training/
- https://www.ideafit.com/progression-models-in-resistance-training-for-healthy-adults

- https://welltech.com/content/worst-knee-exercise-with-safe-alternatives
- https://www.ideafit.com/acsm-on-weight-loss
- Exercise catalogue: `exercise-db` MCP server (search_exercises, get_equipment_alternatives, list_equipment_categories).

Caveats: the web sources above are secondary, general-audience summaries (not primary studies or clinical advice). Nutrition is outside the scope of this program.